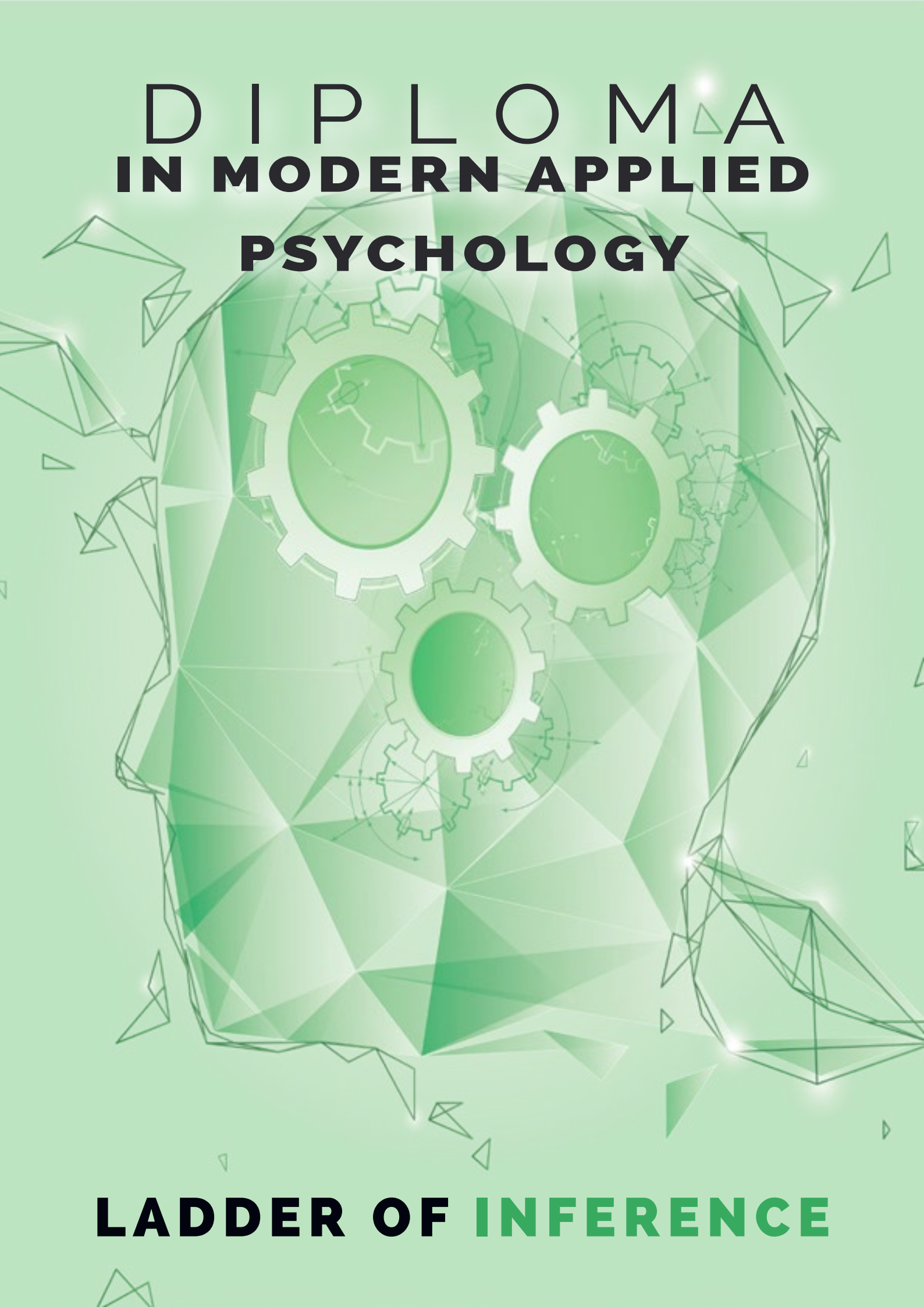


DIPLOMA IN MODERN APPLIED PSYCHOLOGY

The background is a light green field filled with a complex, low-poly geometric pattern. A large, faint silhouette of a human head is centered, facing forward. Inside the head, three interlocking gears are visible, rendered in a slightly darker shade of green. The overall aesthetic is modern and technological, suggesting a connection between psychology and modern science or technology.

LADDER OF INFERENCE

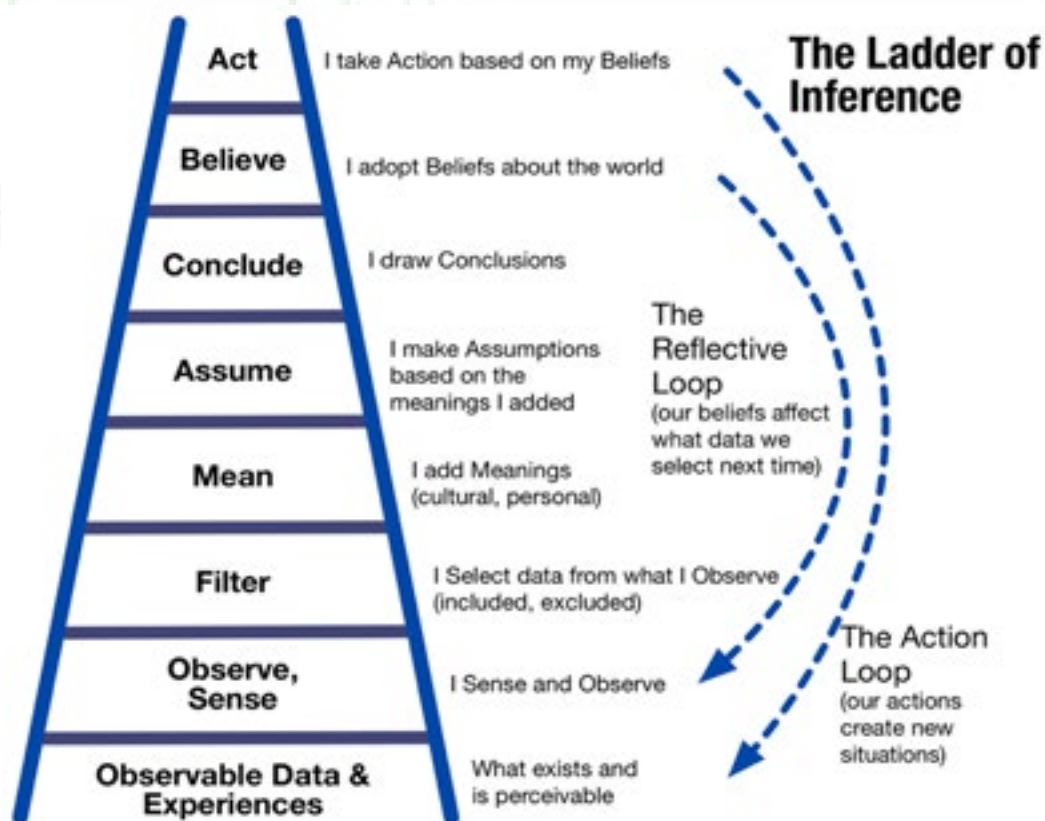
LADDER OF INFERENCE

Have you ever been accused of jumping to the wrong conclusion? We're always under pressure in today's fast-moving world to act now rather than spend time reasoning things through and thinking about the facts. This not only leads us to the wrong conclusions, but it also causes conflict with others.

To maintain the respect and trust in any relationship (personal, intimate or professional), it's crucial that our decisions and actions are founded on reality (and not upon a misinterpretation of the facts). In the same way, when you accept or challenge someone else's conclusions, you must be confident that their reasoning, as well as your own, is firmly grounded in the facts: the 'Ladder of Inference' helps you to do this.

Sometimes known as the 'Process of Abstraction', this tool helps you to understand the thinking steps that often lead an individual to jump to the wrong conclusions, therefore helping you focus on hard reality and facts.

The Ladder of Inference was first put forward by organisational psychologist Chris Argyris and was also used by Peter Senge in 'The Fifth Discipline: The Art and Practice of the Learning Organization'. The Ladder of Inference details the thinking process that individuals go through (often without realising it) to get from the facts to an action. These thinking stages can be referred to as rungs on a ladder and are shown in the image below. Erikson suggest you will experience in your latter stages of psychosocial development



Adapted from Peter Senge's book *The Fifth Discipline Fieldbook*. Copyright 1994



LADDER OF INFERENCE

Observable Data & Experiences:

This is all about internally processing external data. Our lives are quantified and understood through our observations and perceptions (be they accurate or not). Observable data includes people's words, tonality, body language, events and circumstances.

Observe, Sense:

All the data we collect is done so through our senses, but because there will be multiple auditory, kinesthetic, visual, sensual, etc, we have to make sure we categorise each observation to its more accurate sensory input. This helps us become more aware of the data we're taking in which will help us perform better in the next stage.

Filter:

Now that you've assigned and categorised all external data by their senses, it's essential to now filter the data by deciding which data is necessary to observe and which can be ignored. We are naturally inclined to filter data according to our emotional attachment to certain forms of data. Obviously, this selection usually happens subconsciously, but it's interesting to try this on a conscious level.

Mean:

We cannot interpret all data to its correct or intended meaning because, as an observer, we have no idea about the frame of reference of all external communications. We can never know the internal experiences of other people or the cultural significance of everything we consume from our environments. Therefore, we can only add meaning from a personal perspective, no matter how objective we try to be. Our meaning is always determined by our cultural, societal and personal upbringing and experiences.

Assume:

Naturally, the meanings we assign to external data leads to us making assumptions about the data.

Conclude:

The conclusions we draw develop out of the assumptions we choose to solidify, usually based, again, on our emotional inclination. When we draw a conclusion on something, we, in effect, assign a name or word to what is happening, meaning that we've moved from fluid interpretation into a categorised interpretation.

Believe:

Conclusions naturally develop into beliefs which skew our perception of the world and the people in it. Because our beliefs developed from our observation of data, it's natural for us to regard them as objective truths rather than opinion developed out of a perspective.

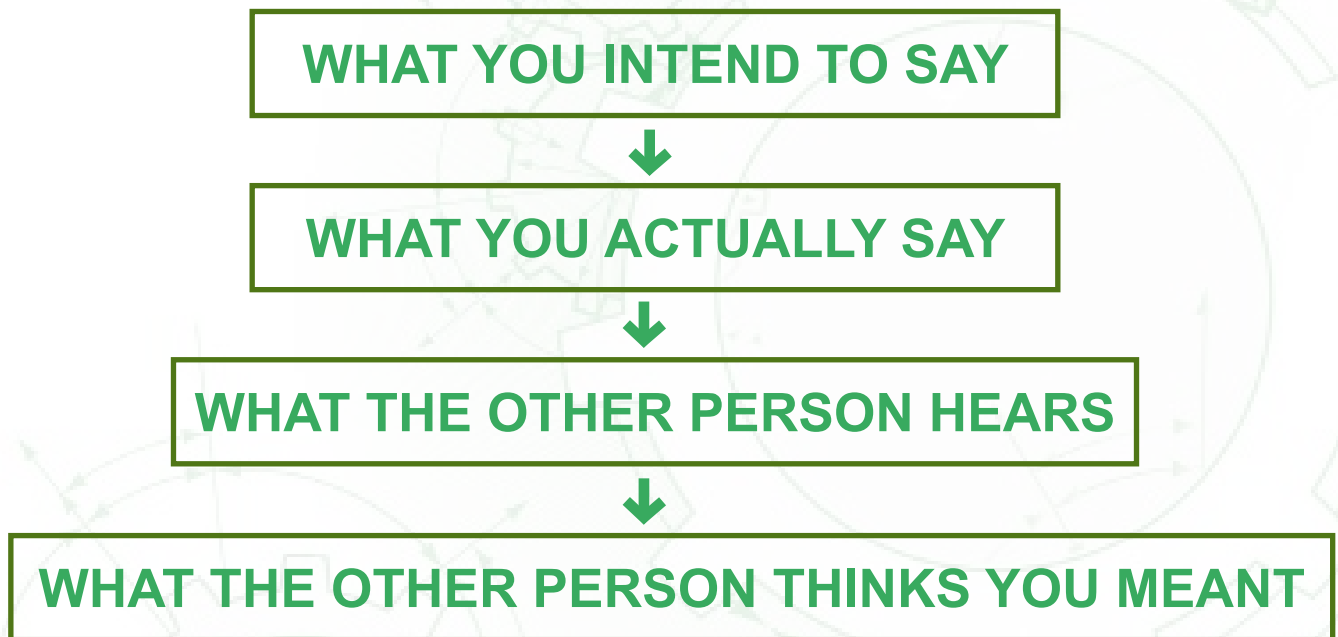
Act:

These beliefs about the world ultimately go on to motivating and justifying our behaviours and ambitions in life. Human behaviour, from having sex to getting married, taking drugs or committing a crime, is motivated and driven by human beliefs.



LADDER OF INFERENCE

When it comes to communication, the ladder of inference can be simplified into a four-stage of communication which looks like this:



At the top of the ladder is 'what we intended to say' i.e. what we should plan to say before we've even opened our mouths. Next, there is 'what we actually say' which nine times out of ten is not an accurate representation of what we meant to say (because we're imperfect communicators). Then there is 'what the other person hears', which again might be far removed from what we've actually said and depends on the degree to which the other person is paying attention. And lastly, at the bottom of the ladder, there is 'what the other person thinks we mean.' At this stage, the other person may jump to conclusions or makes assumptions about what they think we mean by what we've said. An example of an assumption could be if an individual takes negative feedback from a colleague to heart and assumes that their colleague thinks they are awful at their job.

As you can tell, all of this can create a vicious cycle. A person's beliefs can have a huge effect on what they choose to take from what we say and can lead them to completely ignoring the facts of what was said. Soon they are jumping to conclusions – missing the facts and skipping steps in this reasoning process. The Ladder of Inference can help people learn to get back to the facts and use their beliefs and experiences positively, as opposed to allowing them to narrow their field of judgment. Following this reasoning process can lead people to better results which are based on reality, and therefore help them to avoid unnecessary conflict and mistakes.

How to use the theory

The Ladder of Inference helps people to draw better conclusions. We can also use it to help challenge or validate other people's conclusions. This reasoning process helps us to remain objective and, when working or challenging other people, reach a shared conclusion without any conflict. You can use the following steps to challenge thinking using the Ladder of Inference:



LADDER OF INFERENCE

1. Stop! It's time to consider your reasoning.

2. Identify where on the ladder you are. Are you:

- being selective about what you hear?
- Interpreting what you think the other person means?
- Making assumptions?
- Forming or testing conclusions?
- Deciding what to do and why?

3. From your current 'rung', analyse your reasoning by working back up the ladder.

This will help you to trace the facts and reality that you are actually working with. At every stage, ask yourself what you are thinking and why. As you analyse every step, you'll probably need to adjust your reasoning. For example, you may need to extend the information you have selectively heard, or change some assumptions. The following questions will help you to work backwards (coming up the ladder, starting at the bottom):

- Why have you chosen this course of action? Are there other measures you could have considered?
- What belief lead to this action? Was it well-founded?
- Why did you draw this conclusion? Is the conclusion sound?
- What are you assuming, and why? Are your assumptions accurate?
- What data have you chosen to use and why? Have you selected data rigorously?
- What are the real facts that you should be using? Are there other points you could consider?
- With this new sense of reasoning (and perhaps even a wider field of data and more considered assumptions), you can now work down the ladder again – step-by-step!

Tips for Using the Ladder of Inference

You can use the 'Ladder of Inference' at any stage of your thinking process. If you're asking any of the following questions, the model may prove a useful aid:

- Is this the 'right' conclusion?
- Why am I making these assumptions?
- Why do I think this is the 'right' thing to do?
- Is this conclusion based on all the facts?
- Why does she believe that?

When you're working through your reasoning, watch out for rungs that you tend to jump. Do you tend to make assumptions too quickly? Do you tend to choose only part of the information? Consider your tendencies so that you can learn to consider this stage of reasoning more carefully moving forward.

Try explaining your reasoning to a friend or colleague, as doing this will help you to ensure that your argument is sound and of rational judgement. If you are challenging someone else's conclusions, it is important to be able to explain your reasoning to enable you to explain it to the other person in a way that helps you avoid conflict and reach a shared conclusion.

